

# HIS592 World Church History I — Syllabus

## Asia Pacific Theological Seminary

Instructor: Dr. Ang Li Credits: 3 | Location: ARC Room 301 Dates: June 20 – July 7, 2026

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## COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course introduces the history of the Christian church from the post-apostolic period to the dawn of the Reformation era. The main emphasis is to acquaint students with major historical developments, key figures, movements, and doctrines of that time, while asking how this history shapes ministry and scholarship today.

## COURSE OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this course, the student should be able to:

- Discuss the overall history of the world Christian movement through the 15th century, including diverse movements and traditions
- Recognize primary contributors to Christian thought and mission during this period
- Understand major theological controversies and how culture and ecclesial tensions influenced their development
- Understand the rise and spread of Islam and its impact on Christianity in the Mediterranean, Africa, and Asia
- Identify what effect historical and theological developments of this period have had on the church today

## REQUIRED TEXT

González, Justo L. *The Story of Christianity, Volume 1: The Early Church to the Dawn of the Reformation*. Revised and updated ed. HarperOne, 2010.

**Supplemental** (for country-history presentations when González is thin):

- Moffett, Samuel H. *A History of Christianity in Asia, Vol. 1*. HarperSanFrancisco, 1992.
- Jenkins, Philip. *The Lost History of Christianity*. HarperOne, 2008.

## AI POLICY

AI tools (ChatGPT, Claude, etc.) are permitted for brainstorming, source discovery, translation, outlining, and drafting. AI is not a substitute for source verification, oral presentation, or personal ministry reflection. Every major assignment must include a brief **AI Use Report** (one paragraph): what tool was used, how, and what was verified manually.

## COURSE REQUIREMENTS & GRADING

| Assignment                               | %   |
|------------------------------------------|-----|
| Attendance and class participation       | 20% |
| González reading group presentation      | 15% |
| Home country / region group presentation | 25% |
| Final project — Ministry or PhD Track    | 40% |

**Attendance and Participation (20%):** Attend all sessions. Be punctual. Engage in discussions and at least one scripted class interaction (role-play, primary source, or debate) as assigned each term.

**González Reading Group Presentation (15%):** Each of the 7 groups is assigned one block of González chapters and gives a 15–20 minute presentation at the start of the relevant session. Cover: key figures, main developments, one discussion question for the class. A one-page handout or slide set is required. AI may assist with preparation; students handle live Q&A. This replaces weekly reading papers and distributes the survey across the class.

**Home Country / Region Group Presentation (25%):** Groups present a 15-minute class presentation on the history of Christianity in their home country or region using the Three Lenses format (see below). A brief check-in with the instructor is required by Session 6. Students from the Philippines or any country with large numbers may form two sub-groups by region, island cluster, or denomination.

**Final Project (40%):** Students choose one track at the start of the course.

## FINAL PROJECT TRACKS

**Ministry Track** — Video (8–10 min) + 1-page ministry memo + AI Use Report

Choose one historical figure from any period of church history, including the Puritan or missionary era. Present: (1) who they were — their theology, ministry, congregation, family, and failures; (2) what their life and ministry taught you about your own life or ministry; (3) at least 1–2 changes in perspective or things you will do differently as a result. The video should be suitable for sharing with your congregation or ministry supporters.

**Research / PhD Track** — Proposal (4–5 pp.) + 5-min live pitch + AI Use Report

Write a research proposal for a specific doctoral program, including: (1) a gap in the existing historical narrative with specific González page citations; (2) why the gap matters, with brief evaluation of two existing scholarly works; (3) proposed methodology and sources; (4) why this

specific program, based on faculty profiles or recent dissertations. Defend with a 5-min pitch and 3 min of peer Q&A.

## GONZÁLEZ READING GROUP PRESENTATIONS

The class is divided into 7 groups. Each group is assigned one block of the course reading and presents it to the class at the start of the relevant session. This is the primary mode of covering the textbook — presentations replace reading papers.

| Group | González Block | Session | Content                                                                   |
|-------|----------------|---------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1     | Ch. 1–4        | 1       | Post-apostolic world, spread of the faith, Jewish and Greco-Roman context |
| 2     | Ch. 5–12       | 2       | Persecution, apologists, canon, early fathers, worship and church life    |
| 3     | Ch. 13–24      | 3       | Constantine, Nicaea, monasticism, Athanasius, Cappadocians, Augustine     |
| 4     | Ch. 25–28      | 4       | Eastern Christianity, Christological debates, Islam’s rise                |
| 5     | Ch. 29–31      | 5       | Charlemagne, papal reform, church-state conflict, Crusades                |
| 6     | Ch. 32–34      | 6       | Mendicants, scholasticism, schism, Wycliffe, Huss, popular reform         |
| 7     | Ch. 35+        | 7       | Renaissance, humanism, threshold of Reformation, global continuities      |

Presentation requirements: 15–20 minutes, one handout or slide set, minimum 2 sources beyond González, AI Use Report, 2 discussion questions for the class.

## HOME COUNTRY / REGION PRESENTATION — THREE LENSES FORMAT

Every group structures their 15 minutes the same way:

1. **González or Selected Bibliography Narrative (4 min):** What does González/others say about your region, and what does he miss? Quote him directly.
2. **Primary Tradition or Figure (6 min):** Who or what carried Christianity in, and what did it cost? If your tradition has a hymn or chant or other interactive element with historical roots, use it.
3. **The Inheritance Question (5 min, incl. 2 min class response):** Pick a theme from González/Selected Bibliography and say how it arrived in your country and what your church did with it.

*Session 1 task:* Groups form and choose their country or region. Presentation angle and sources to be discussed with instructor by Session 6.

## PLAGIARISM POLICY

APTS considers plagiarism a serious violation of Christian integrity and academic ethics. Plagiarism involves using material written by another without proper citation or representing material written by another as one's own work, including undisclosed AI-generated content. Penalties can include failing the assignment, failing the course, or expulsion.

## TENTATIVE CLASS SCHEDULE

| Session | Date    | Day | Time         | Topic                                                                                     | González |
|---------|---------|-----|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 1       | June 20 | Sat | 1:00–5:00 PM | Course intro;<br>post-apostolic<br>world; groups<br>formed —<br><i>Grp 1<br/>presents</i> | Ch. 1–4  |
| 2       | June 22 | Mon | 1:00–5:00 PM | Persecution,<br>apologetics,<br>canon, early<br>fathers —<br><i>Grp 2<br/>presents</i>    | Ch. 5–12 |

| Session | Date    | Day | Time                                    | Topic                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | González  |
|---------|---------|-----|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| 3       | June 29 | Mon | 8:00<br>AM–12:00<br>NN;<br>1:00–5:20 PM | Constantine,<br>Nicaea,<br>monasticism,<br>Donatism;<br>Athanasius,<br>Cappado-<br>cians,<br>Augustine —<br><i>Grp 3</i><br><i>presents;</i><br><i>Role-play:</i><br><i>Bishop's</i><br><i>Dilemma;</i><br><i>Hot-seat</i><br><i>interview</i> | Ch. 13–24 |
| 4       | July 1  | Wed | 1:00–5:20 PM                            | Christianity<br>beyond<br>Rome; Chris-<br>tological<br>debates;<br>Islam — <i>Grp</i><br><i>4 presents;</i><br><i>Chalcedon</i><br><i>Courtroom</i>                                                                                            | Ch. 25–28 |
| 5       | July 3  | Fri | 1:00–5:20 PM                            | Charlemagne,<br>papal reform,<br>church-state,<br>Crusades —<br><i>Grp 5</i><br><i>presents</i>                                                                                                                                                | Ch. 29–31 |
| 6       | July 4  | Sat | 8:00<br>AM–12:00<br>NN;<br>1:00–5:20 PM | High<br>medieval:<br>mendicants,<br>scholasticism,<br>mission —<br><i>Grp 6</i><br><i>presents;</i><br><i>check-ins.</i><br>Schism,<br>Wycliffe,<br>Huss,<br>popular<br>reform —<br><i>Primary</i><br><i>Source</i><br><i>Workshop</i>         | Ch. 32–34 |

| Session | Date   | Day | Time                                    | Topic                                                                                                                                                                               | González |
|---------|--------|-----|-----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 7       | July 6 | Mon | 8:00<br>AM–12:00<br>NN;<br>1:00–5:20 PM | Renaissance,<br>humanism,<br>Reformation<br>threshold —<br><i>Grp 7</i><br><i>presents.</i><br>Country<br>presentations;<br>final track<br>showcases;<br><b>Looking<br/>Forward</b> | Ch. 35+  |

*Final submissions due: July 8, 2026*

## SELECTED BIBLIOGRAPHY

- González, Justo L. *The Story of Christianity, Volume 1*. HarperOne, 2010.
- Jenkins, Philip. *The Lost History of Christianity*. HarperOne, 2008.
- Moffett, Samuel H. *A History of Christianity in Asia, Vol. 1*. HarperSanFrancisco, 1992.
- Irvin, Dale T. and Scott W. Sunquist. *History of the World Christian Movement, Vol. 1*. Orbis, 2001.
- Shelley, Bruce L. *Church History in Plain Language*. 4th ed. Thomas Nelson, 2013.
- Chua, Tony, comp. *History Reader for World Church History I*. 2022.